

No Hurdle Too Big

For those who have tracked Avinash Sable's rise in the past few years, his performance—finishing 0.5 seconds shy of race winner, Kenya's Abraham Kibiwot—was no surprise. The Beed-born athlete didn't just break the national record (8.11.20), but at Tokyo 2021, became the country's first steeplechaser to qualify for the Olympics since 1952. Sable's affinity for running began when he was six covering the 6 km distance between home and school on foot. Having finished his 12th, Sable joined the 5 Mahar regiment of the Indian Army. It was his colleagues there who encouraged him to give competitive running a shot. Once he started, there was no looking back. Sable attributed his strong showing at the CWG to training stints abroad where he partnered with international athletes. "If I had trained in India, I would have just kept breaking national records but would never have been able to challenge the Kenyans for a medal," he says. —*SS*



dabbled in 400 metres and long jump before setting his heart on the high jump. He made a mark at the junior level and soon caught the eye of JSW Sports who signed him on.

The national indoor and outdoor record holder, Shankar recently completed his bachelor's degree in finance and master's in accounting from Kansas State University where he was on a collegiate sports scholarship. A two-time National Collegiate Athletic Association (NCAA) champion there, Shankar's goals now include crossing the 2.3 metre barrier and qualifying for his first World Championships. He's also focusing on the decathlon with a bid to qualifying in the discipline for next year's Asian Games. –SS



ELDHOSE PAUL, 25

Triple Jump, GOLD

Triple delights

With Neeraj Chopra skipping the Games due to injury, expectations were not high for a field athletics gold medal. On August 7, though, a 25-year-old Indian Navy man made history winning India its first gold medal in the triple jump. The 25-year-old from Kolencherry in Ernakulam district, Kerala, cleared 17.03 metres, with compatriot Abdulla Aboobacker Narangolintevid coming in just 0.01 metre behind. Less than a month back, Paul had also become the first Indian to qualify for the triple jump finals of the World Athletics Championships.

Paul dedicated his victory to his grandmother Mariyamma, who raised him after his mother's demise when he was just five. At just 5'8", Paul's physique was not deemed ideal for triple jumpers. But coach and professor T.P. Ouseph, at his alma mater Mar Athanasius College, Kothamangalam, believed in his talent. Paul likes to keep it simple at competitions. "I focus on my performance and avoid distractions," he told INDIA TODAY.

–Jeemon Jacob